The Drowned Man

By Neil Simon

TRAMP: Psst! You, sir. Can I have a word with you, sir?

WRITER: Who's there?... I can't see you in the dark.

TRAMP: 'Evening, sir... I was wondering, sir, if you might be in the mood for a little, er, "entertainment" this evening?

WRITER: "Entertainment"? I'm sure I don't know what you're talking about.

TRAMP: Sure you do, sir. Entertainment... Amusement, so to speak. A little "diversion," if you know what I mean.

INTRODUCTION

Actor 1: *"What would you do for money?" Some people would eat a spider as big as the palms of their hands. Some people would go weeks on end without bathing and brushing their teeth while they rough it on some remote island. Some people would marry a perfect stranger. All of these things are done today on national television to meet the public's need for entertainment.*

Actor 2: *Although in 1974 reality television hadn't evolved . . . Neil Simon offers his prophetic vision of what public entertainment was to become: "The Drowned Man" from The Good Doctor by Neil Simon.*

TRAMP: You've never witnessed anything like this before, that I promise you. This is a once-in-a-lifetime offer... Not even a little bit curious?

WRITER: Curiosity is the nature of my profession. But I try to keep it morally elevated... Excuse me.

TRAMP: Perhaps you're right, sir. On second thought, this might be too much for a gentleman of your "sensitivities."

WRITER: Wait!

TRAMP: Got you with that last one, didn't I?

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WRITER: I'm just asking, mind you, but, er... just exactly what is this "entertainment" you speak of?

TRAMP: Well, sir, how would you like to see -- a drowned man?

WRITER: I beg your pardon?

TRAMP: A drowned man! A man with his lungs filled up with salt water and stone dead from drowning. How much would you pay to see that?

WRITER: Pay? Pay to see a drowned man? Are you insane? I wouldn't look at a drowned man if they paid me. Why would I want to see a drowned man? What's the point in looking at a man who drowned? You're mad! Get out of here!

TRAMP: Three rubles, sir. That's all it'll cost you. Three rubles to see him first, before he's in the water, then in the agonizing act of drowning and then the grand finale, the man already drowned, rest his soul.

WRITER: What are you saying? That the man isn't drowned yet? That he's still alive and well?

TRAMP: Not only alive and well, but dry as bone and standing before you. I'm the drowned man, sir.

WRITER: You? You're going to drown yourself for three rubles? You expect to charge me for your own suicide?... I must get away from this lunatic.

TRAMP: No, no, no, you've got it all wrong, sir. I don't actually drown. I impersonate a drowned man. I jump into the icy cold water, splash around a bit, flail my arms, yell for help a few times, go under -- bubble, bubble, bubble -- and then come up floating head down, all puffy like. It sends a chill up your spine... Three rubles for individual performances, special rates for groups. Show starts in two minutes.

WRITER: I can't believe I'm actually discussing the price of admission to a drowning.

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TRAMP: You miss the whole point, sir. This is not some sort of cheap thrill. It's a rich tableau filled with social implications. A drama, not tragic, but ironical, in view of its comic features.

WRITER: Comic? What's comic about it?

TRAMP: I blow up my cheeks and bulge my eyes out. Yell for help in a high squeaky voice. Sounds like a pig squealing. I'm the only one on the waterfront who can do it.

WRITER: Do you actually expect me to pay to hear an underwater pig squealer?

TRAMP: I've just had a very successful season, sir. Sold out in August. What do you say, sir? Would you like me to book you now for the dinner show?

WRITER: What do mean, dinner show?

TRAMP: I jump in, flail around and throw you a nice fish. I think the halibuts are running now, sir.

WRITER: Why do I stand here listening to this?

TRAMP: I wish you'd make up your mind soon, sir. In five minutes that restaurant throws its garbage in the water. Then it's messy. I have my pride.

WRITER: To hell with your pride. It doesn't prevent you from making a living imitating a deceased swimmer.

TRAMP: You sure know how to strike at a man's vulnerable points. That was cruel, sir.

WRITER: I'm sorry. I didn't mean to be cruel.

TRAMP: You completely overlook the finer points to my profession. Look here, did you ever see a coal miner at the end of a day? Filth and grime all over his body. Soot up his nostrils and in his ears, black grit in his teeth. Disgusting... Or a barber who goes home at night with the cuttings of other people's hair sticking to his hands. It gets in his bread, in his soup, it's nauseating... Do you know where a surgeon puts his fingers--

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WRITER: Oh, please.

TRAMP: --or a farmer his feet? Every man who works eventually touches something filthy. On the other hand, I deal with water. Water is wet, it's clean, it's purifying. I don't have to take a bath when I come home at night. I've done it. Can you day the same, sir?

WRITER: Do you think I'm going to discuss my toilet habits with you? My God, you're infuriating. There must be a carriage around here. Cabbie! Cabbie!

TRAMP: You'll regret it. You'll be back one night, bored to death, dying to see a good drowning and I'll be gone. This is my last week here. I close on Sunday... Next week I'm in Yalta. Just for you I am reducing my price to an all time low. Eighty kopecks.

WRITER: Eighty?! Eighty, you thief! You conniving, wretched, deceiving little thief, I won't pay you more than sixty!

TRAMP: Sixty? Sixty kopeks for a drowning? But where's my profit? My towels cost me forty kopeks. And another forty for the fella who fishes me out. I'd be losing money on it. What's the point? I might as well stay under.

WRITER: You can't cheat me, sir. Sixty kopecks for the drowning, take it or leave it.

TRAMP: You're a hard man, sir. A hard man... Sixty kopeks it is. I pray to God my son doesn't want to be a drowner.

WRITER: -thirty-forty-fifty-sixty. There's your money. Now where shall I stand?

TRAMP: Right on the edge of the dock, sir. Right up close, that's where you'll see all the action.

WRITER: It's a big dark down there. You're sure I'll be able to see well?

TRAMP: That's what makes it so eerie. The eerier, the more entertaining. All the action's in the last ten seconds anyway... Well, here I go. Oh, I almost forgot. When I come up for the third time, yell at the top of your lungs, Popnichefsky! Popnichefsky!

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WRITER: Who's Popnichefsky?

TRAMP: He's the fellow who jumps in after me. I can't swim, sir.

WRITER: You can't swim! Are you trying to tell me you're going to drown without knowing how to swim?

TRAMP: That's what makes it so exciting. Popnichefsky always waits till the very last second before jumping in and pulling me out. He's in that restaurant, sir, having a drink. Popnichefsky. Don't forget the name, sir... Well, I hope you enjoy the show. If you like it, tell your friends... In the soup, as we say. (He jumps in, yells for help) Help! Help, I'm drowning! I can't swim, help!

WRITER: Over here. A little toward me... I can't see you too well there...

TRAMP: Oh, God! Help! Help, somebody, I'm drowning!

WRITER: Good, very good. Yes, well, that's enough of that. I don't want to see that part any more. I don't have all night... Can you drown now?

TRAMP: Aggglllll....

WRITER: Do you hear me? I would like to have you drown now... Where the devil is he? Ahh, there you are... That's the third time, isn't it? (About to call for Popnichefsky) Good heavens, what was that fellow's name?

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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